but there is his brother Shehbaz Sharif and Shehbaz's son Hamza, who are vying to take up the mantle from the septuagenarian leader. While the family presents a united front, there is enough gossip around about frictions within. And there is the bitterness such dynastic politics has on the second tier leadership that seems to be shut out of the top positions.

As political analyst Zaigham Khan puts it, the PML-N's leadership style consists of three concentric circles. At its innermost level is the immediate family who are favoured to occupy almost all the main positions—this includes former finance minister Ishaq Dar whose son is married to Nawaz's younger daughter; the second circle consists of the Punjabi Kashmiri clan that the Sharifs are part of, and the third circle comprises those from their hometown Lahore and the environs of the PML-N stronghold, the Grand Trunk Road. This leaves everyone else, including from the other provinces, the youth and those not part of these circles out in the cold and resentful. In Pakistan's changing demographic—which Imran Khan had tapped into—this sort of leadership may not be sustainable in the long term. But whether Sharif recognises this flaw, or can do anything about it, is questionable.

Finally, there is the question of what the establishment wants. Despite the apparent bonhomie, it doesn't look likely that the army would ideally want to have Sharif back at the helm—if not because Sharif's history of relations with the army leadership has never been smooth, then because of the optics of the establishment being forced to turn to him after ousting him for a third time. So, they may be agreeable to him playing kingmaker but not be the king.

Despite the apparent bonhomie, the army ideally may not want Nawaz back at the helm because of past experience. They may be more agreeable to him playing kingmaker but not be the king

Party insiders report that a message was conveyed to Sharif a few months ago to not contest for the prime ministership himself, to keep Maryam out of the running and to leave the field for his brother Shehbaz—who the army feels far more comfortable with. Some analysts feel that Nawaz's current posturing might be to exert pressure on the establishment to at least, as a compromise, accept Maryam as the next chief minister of Punjab. Under such a deal, Nawaz would not take up the mantle of prime minister, though it might be difficult to explain such a turnaround given the current PML-N narrative. Of course, this is speculative. Given the desperation of the establishment to tamp down on the lingering popularity of Imran Khan's Pakistan Tehreek-i-Insaf (PTI)—despite his being in jail, there are real fears that the economic situation might lead to a backlash, especially in Punjab—Sharif might have decided to chart his own narrative.

IMRAN BLACKED OUT

For his part, Imran continues to be in jail and no one really expects him to be let out anytime soon. He has been convicted by one court of corruption—which, unless the ruling is overturned on appeal, will see him disqualified from running for office for five years—and has also been indicted in a far more serious Official Secrets Act case, for allegedly leaking a confidential and encrypted diplomatic cable known as a 'cypher' after his removal from office. He is completely blacked out from the electronic media and his party is in tatters, with most of its top leadership either in detention, in hiding or having switched sides or abandoned politics altogether, allegedly under pressure from the army establishment. Many have appeared on television to recant their support for Imran Khan and blamed him for leading the cadre astray. The party's senior vice president and former foreign minister Shah Mahmood Qureshi has also been indicted in the cypher case along with Imran.

The biggest blow to Imran has come from the events of May 9 and 10, in which the party attempted to attack symbols of the state and particularly of the military. Those shocking acts of mob vandalism—about which there is growing evidence that they were pre-planned—have come to bite the PTI. It is said that the new army chief, Gen. Asim Munir, is convinced the attacks were designed to instigate a mutiny within the army against him. After an initial bout of confusion, he has reasserted his control over the army leadership, leading to the purging of some senior officers with suspect loyalties as well as a harsh crackdown on the PTI.

Although a Supreme Court bench recently declared the military trials of those allegedly involved attacking military installations as unconstitutional—they will now have to be conducted in civilian courts—the army seems to be in no mood to be lenient to the perpetrators. A day after the officially sanctioned PML-N *jalsa* in Lahore, which attracted tens of thousands of people, a small protest demonstration of about 200 people by PTI faced a crackdown. There is no doubt in anyone's mind about who really calls the shots.

But coming back to Nawaz Sharif, could he have his way even in the face of the establishment's wishes? After all, former PM Benazir Bhutto, too, had reneged on a deal with former dictator Gen. Musharraf not to return until the 2007 elections, once she got the upper hand. One will discover over the next three months whether Sharif has the same wiliness, political savvy and courage. ■